

Session 12: Garden Imagery in the Ancient Near East

Key Takeaways

- Garden imagery is how the biblical authors talk about the space where Heaven and Earth overlap.
- Garden imagery is also used in other ancient Near Eastern iconography to represent divine space, similar to but also different from the biblical concept.

Word Study: Delight/Eden — *Eden* (עֵדֶן)

The word “eden” (עֵדֶן) is used in two overlapping ways in the Hebrew Bible.

Eden as Luxuriance or Delight

2 Samuel 1:24 NKJV*

O daughters of Israel, weep over Saul, Who clothed you in scarlet with **luxuries (lit. “edens”)** who put ornaments of gold on your apparel.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 36:7-8 NIV

How priceless is your unfailing love, O God!
People take refuge in the shadow of your wings.
They feast on the abundance of your house;
you give them drink from your river of **delights (lit. “edens”)**.

Jeremiah 51:34 NIV

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon has devoured us, he has thrown us into confusion, he has made us an empty jar. Like a serpent he has swallowed us and filled his stomach with our **delicacies (lit. “edens”)**, and then has spewed us out.

Eden as the Cosmic Meeting of Heaven and Earth

The cosmic land called “Delight/Eden” is consistently referred back to in the Hebrew Bible as a meeting place of Heaven and Earth, which is the source of all life and abundance outside of Eden.

Isaiah 51:3 NIV

The LORD will surely comfort **Zion** and will look with compassion on all her ruins; he will make her deserts **like Eden** her wastelands like the garden of the LORD. Joy and gladness will be found in her, thanksgiving and the sound of singing.

Ezekiel 31:3-4, 9 NIV

³ Consider **Assyria** once a cedar in Lebanon, with beautiful branches overshadowing the forest; it towered on high, its top above the thick foliage. ⁴ The waters nourished it, deep springs made it grow tall; their streams flowed all around its base and sent their channels to all the trees of the field ... ⁹ I made it beautiful with abundant branches, the envy of all **the trees of Eden** in **the garden of God**.

Ezekiel 36:35 NIV

They will say, “**This land** that was laid waste has become **like the garden of Eden**; the cities that were lying in ruins, desolate and destroyed, are now fortified and inhabited.”

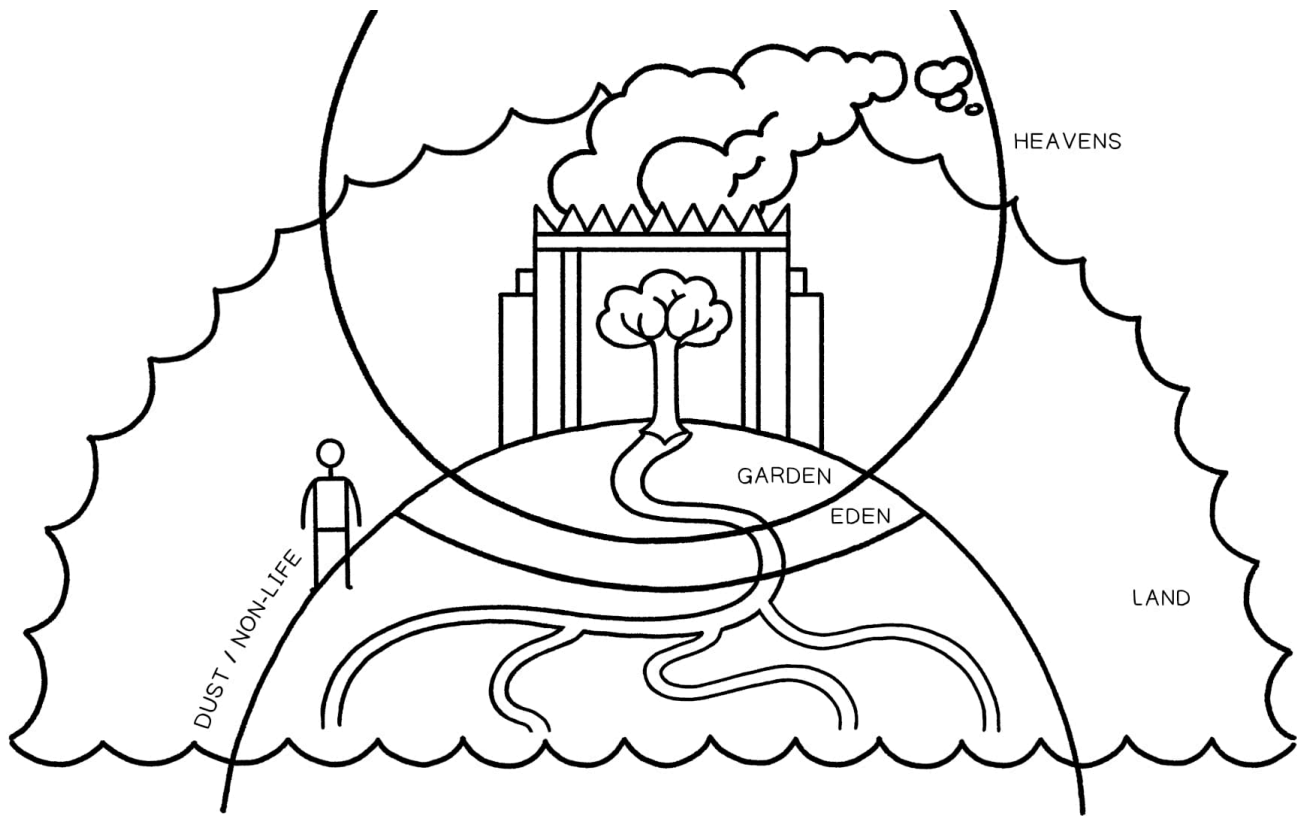
Ezekiel 28:13-14 NASB

You were in **Eden, the garden of God** ... You were on **the holy mountain of God**; you walked in the midst of the stones of fire.

Psalms 46:1-7 NASB

¹ God is our refuge and strength,
a very present help in trouble.
² Therefore we will not fear, though the earth should change
and though the mountains slip into the heart of the sea;
³ though its waters roar and foam,
though the mountains quake at its swelling pride.
Selah.
⁴ There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God,
the holy dwelling places of the Most High.
⁵ God is in the midst of her, she will not be moved;
God will help her when morning dawns.
⁶ The nations made an uproar, the kingdoms tottered;
he raised his voice, the earth melted.
⁷ The LORD of hosts is with us;
The God of Jacob is our stronghold.
Selah.

Images of Heaven on Earth



Garden of Eden Pattern. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

God, the high place that sources the river, and the city up on high all become mapped onto each other as images pointing to a greater reality.

Garden as Paradise

200 years before Jesus, Hebrew scholars translated their Hebrew Bible into Greek. This version, called the Septuagint, translated the word “gan” to “paradeisos,” which is where the English word “paradise” comes from.

Luke 23:42-44 NASB

⁴² And he was saying, “Jesus, remember me when you come in your kingdom!” ⁴³ And he said to him, “Truly I say to you, today you shall be with me in **Paradise**.” ⁴⁴ It was now about the sixth hour, and darkness fell over the whole land until the ninth hour.”

Revelation 21:1-4 NASB

¹ Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth passed away, and there is no longer any sea. ² And I saw the **holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God**, made ready as a bride adorned for her husband. ³ And I heard a loud voice from the throne, saying, “Behold, the tabernacle of God is among men, and he will dwell among them, and they shall be his people, and God himself will be among them, ⁴ and he will wipe away every tear from their eyes; and there will no longer be any death; there will no longer be any mourning, or crying, or pain; the first things have passed away.”

Revelation 22:1-2 NASB

¹ Then he showed me a **river of the water of life**, clear as crystal, **coming from the throne of God and of the Lamb**, ² in the middle of its street. On either side of the river was the tree of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit every month; and the leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.

Word Study: Planted in the East/of Old — Qedem (קדם)

The word *qedem* can be used geographically (to mean “east”) or temporally (to mean “before”). The use is picked up and elaborated in Genesis 3:24 and 4:16.

Genesis 3:24 NASB

So he drove the man out; and **at the east** (מקדם) of the garden of Eden, he stationed the cherubim and the flaming sword which turned every direction to guard the way to the tree of life.

Genesis 4:16 NASB

Then Cain went out from the presence of the LORD, and settled in the land of Nod, **east** (קדמת) of Eden.

This geographical use of Eden is clear, but the question is whether the word “*miqeddem*” has a double meaning in [Genesis 2:8](#), because the temporal use of this word is very common.

Isaiah 45:21 NIV

Declare what is to be, present it—let them take counsel together. Who foretold this long ago, who declared it from the **distant past** (מקדם)? Was it not I, the LORD? And there is no God apart from me, a righteous God and a Savior; there is none but me.

Micah 5:2 NIV

But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though you are small among the clans of Judah, out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel, whose origins are **from of old** (מקדם), from ancient times.

Habakkuk 1:12 NIV*

LORD, are you not from **antiquity** (מקדם)? My God, my Holy One, you will never die. You, LORD, have appointed them to execute judgment; you, my Rock, have ordained them to punish.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 77:11-12 NIV*

¹¹ I will remember the deeds of the LORD; yes, I will remember your miracles **of long ago** (מקדם). ¹² I will consider all your works and meditate on all your mighty deeds.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the earliest history of interpretation, the word was understood both ways.

1. Geographical: Old Greek (κατα ἀνατολας, “from eastward”)

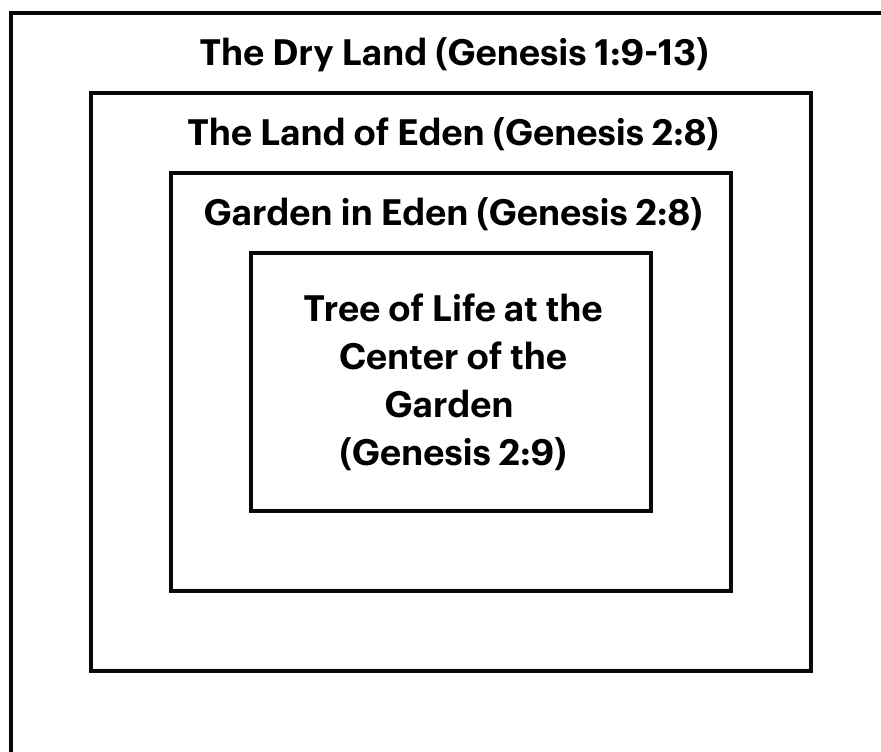
2. Temporal: Latin Vulgate (*a principio*, “from the beginning”), and early Septuagint revisers (Aquila *ἀπο ἀρχῆθεν*, Symmachus *ἐκ πρωτης*, Theodotian *ἐν πρωτοις*), and all of the Aramaic Targums (Neofiti, Pseudo-Jonathan)

“‘Before the creation of the world a garden had been planted by the Memra of the Lord God from Eden for the righteous’—The view expressed here by Pseudo-Jonathan that the garden of Eden was created before the creation of the world is debated in Genesis Rabbah 15, 3. The garden of Eden is included among the ten things that were created on the eve of the first Sabbath. According to Jubilees 2, 7 and 2 Enoch 30, 1, the garden of Eden was created on the third day.”

Maher, Michael (1992). *Targum Pseudo-Jonathan: Genesis (The Aramaic Bible) (Volume 1)*. Michael Glazier.

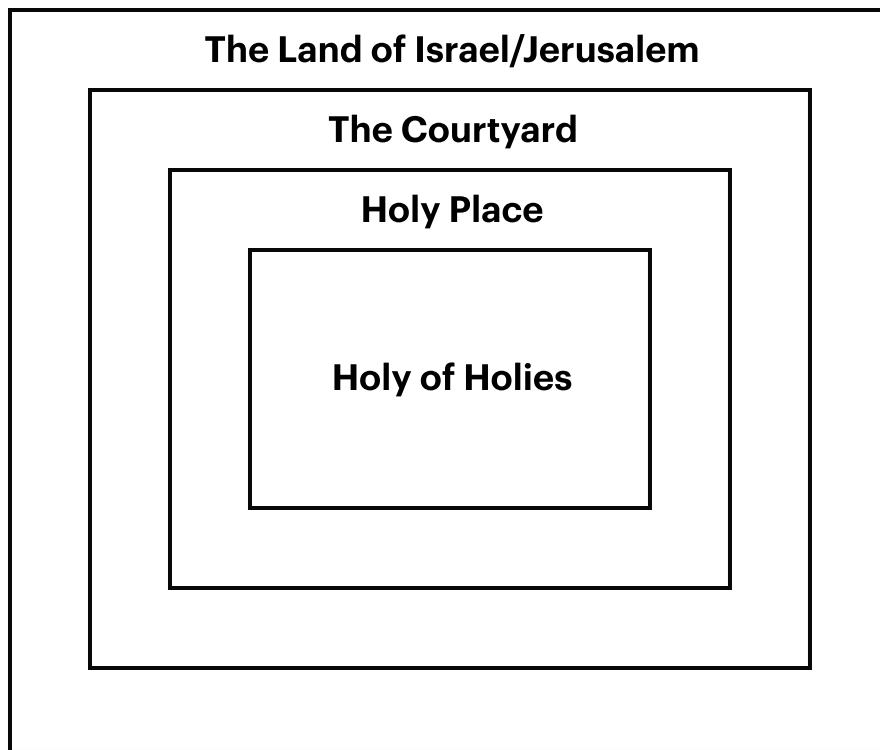
The Three-Part Geography of Eden and Tabernacle

The geography of Eden within the dry land of Genesis 1-3 depicts a three-part topography.



Three-Part Eden Geography Diagram. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

This conception of the garden of Eden on the dry land provides a symbolic template for Israel’s tabernacle temple, especially as described in Ezekiel’s ideal/restored temple (Ezek. 40-48).



Three-Part Tabernacle Layout. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

In his book *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?*, Michel Morales depicts the similarities between the garden and the tabernacle.

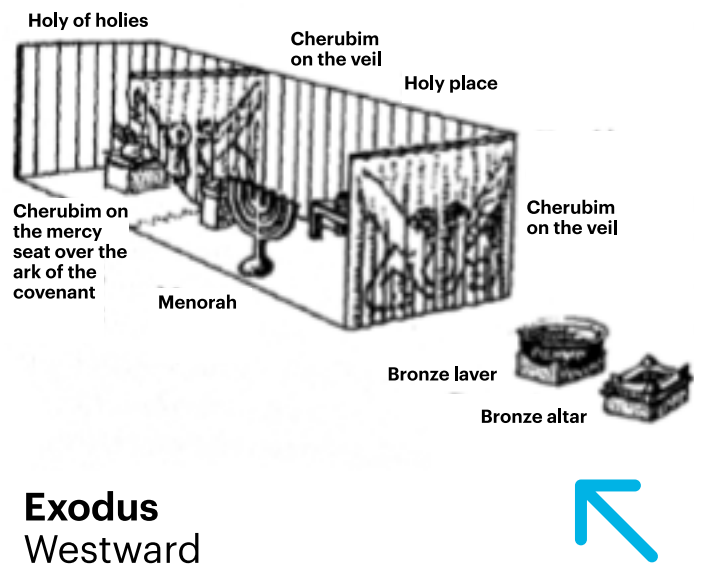
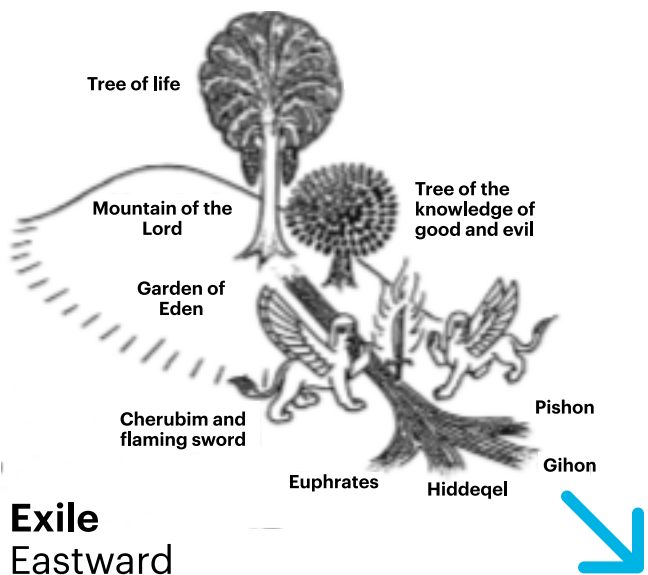


Image adapted from Morales, Michael L. (2015). *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*. IVP Academic.

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The Tree of Life

The tree of life is the tree in the center of the garden that imparts eternal life.

Genesis 2:9 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh God caused to sprout every tree from the ground that is pleasing to the sight and good for food; **and the tree of life was in the middle of the garden, and the tree of knowing of good and bad.**

Genesis 3:22 NASB

Then the LORD God said, "Behold, the man has become like one of us, knowing good and evil; and now, **he might stretch out his hand, and take also from the tree of life, and eat, and live forever.**"

"[The tree of life] represents life that is beyond the original life that God breathed into human. The first human by nature is susceptible to death ... Nevertheless, continued eating from the tree could renew life and prevent death. Apart from disobedience to God's command, mortals had access to this tree ... The tree of life allows humanity to transcend its mortality, the state in which it was created on the sixth day, so it can move to a higher dimension ... to eternal life and immortality. As one partakes of this ... fruit by faith, one participates in this eternal life. This highest potency of life was available in the garden and becomes once again available to us as we reenter the temple-garden through the second Adam ... and look forward to the resurrection of our bodies."

Waltke, Bruce; Yu, Charles (2007). [*An Old Testament Theology: An Exegetical, Canonical, and Thematic Approach*](#). Zondervan.

The Tree of Life in Ancient Near Eastern Perspective

The tree of life was an iconic image in the ancient world. It's helpful to compare and contrast this tree's significance in Mesopotamian, Canaanite, and Egyptian culture with the biblical portrait.

"As any astute tourist quickly observes, the landscape of much the Near East is predominantly stark and barren. The land is comprised of innumerable shades of brown, with only brief interjections of green and blue. The higher in elevation one goes, the greener the picture becomes. Consequently, mountains and rivers, along with the forests that adorn them, seem to be natural focal points anyone who lives or travels in these lands. The ancient peoples, from the remote western world of Egypt to the eastern river marshes of Babylonia, lived in the land, not simply on it. They were all agrarian cultures, whose livelihood was found and maintained among the shade, fruit, shelter, and beauty of their trees. As a result, there can be little doubt that this lifestyle had a significant effect on these ancient cultures and the way they perceived the world. Trees were some of the most sacred elements in ancient near Eastern civilizations."

Osborne, William (2018). [*Trees and Kings: A Comparative Analysis of Tree Imagery in Israel's Prophetic Tradition and the Ancient Near East*](#). Eisenbrauns.

Sacred Trees in Ancient Egypt

Nut, the sky goddess, who is often associated with the sky-dome and the gift of rain, is also often portrayed as a tree that supplies fruit, water, and life for the land.

“These images and strong associations between the tree and the goddess do not indicate that the ancients necessarily believed the tree was equal to the deity, but that the god was like the tree, or at least that the tree was an embodiment of the deity ...”

Osborne, William (2018). [*Trees and Kings: A Comparative Analysis of Tree Imagery in Israel's Prophetic Tradition and the Ancient Near East*](#). Eisenbrauns.

Egyptian Kings as Trees

The productivity of ancient Egypt was completely dependent upon the Nile, which annually flooded and irrigated the shores and deltas. Osiris was the deity associated with the Nile, and the one who provided fertility for the land through the waters. In Egyptian mythology, Osiris was believed to have a son named Horus, who was incarnate as the Pharaoh. The king stood as the sole mediator between the gods and the people, responsible for fertility and order.



[Wikipedia](#).

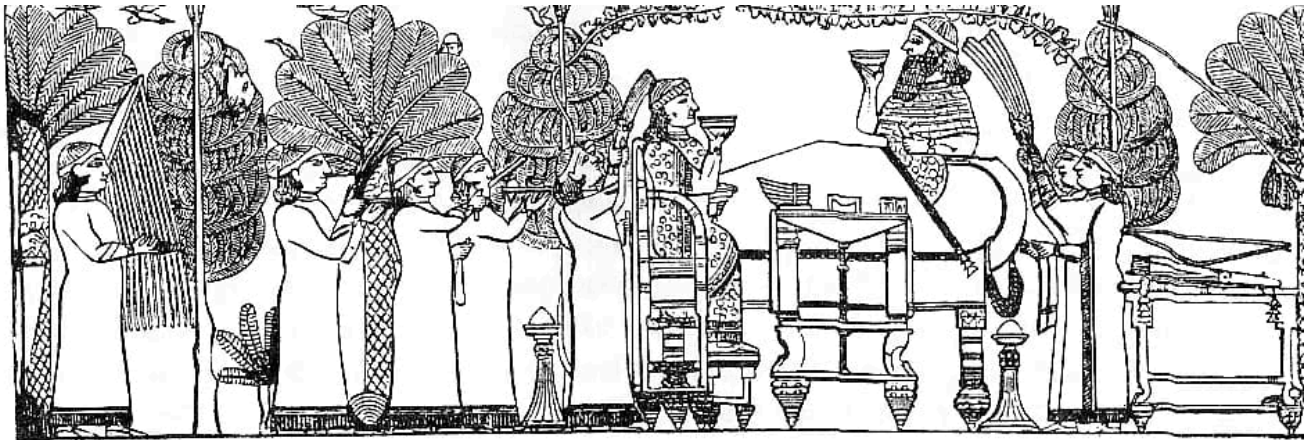
Temple of Karnak: King Sety I (early 1200s B.C.) is sitting in the middle of a tree, being crowned and given a scepter by Thoth who is writing his name on the leaves of the tree. It's an image for the king's role as a god giving life to the land through the sacred tree.



King, Hugo (2011). [Flickr](#).

Trees in Mesopotamian Culture (Assyria and Babylon)

Trees and gardens were associated with the royal gardens of imperial kings. The image below depicts a wall relief of Assyrian king Asshurbanipal's garden parties (7th century B.C.).

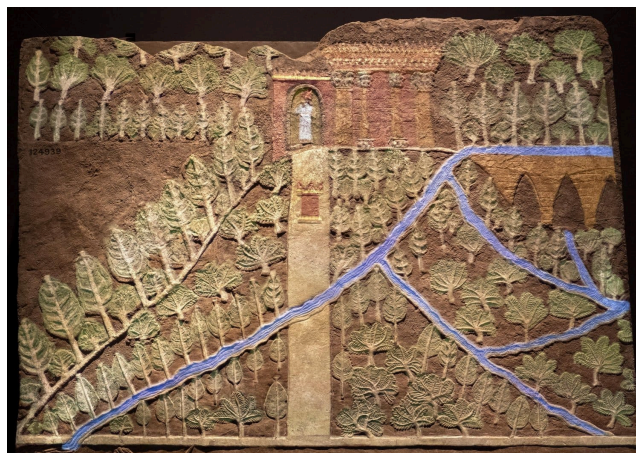


[Wikimedia Commons.](#)

Asshurbanipal's Royal Garden in Nimrud Designed a Microcosm of His Empire

"By the will of the gods, vines, fruit trees of all kinds, olive trees, aromatic trees, flourished greatly in my gardens. Cypress trees ... grew tall and sent out shoots. I created a marsh for the flow of water for the gardens ... Birds of the heavens, herons ... boars and deer ... gave birth in abundance."

Royal Inscriptions of Sennacherib, Text #8

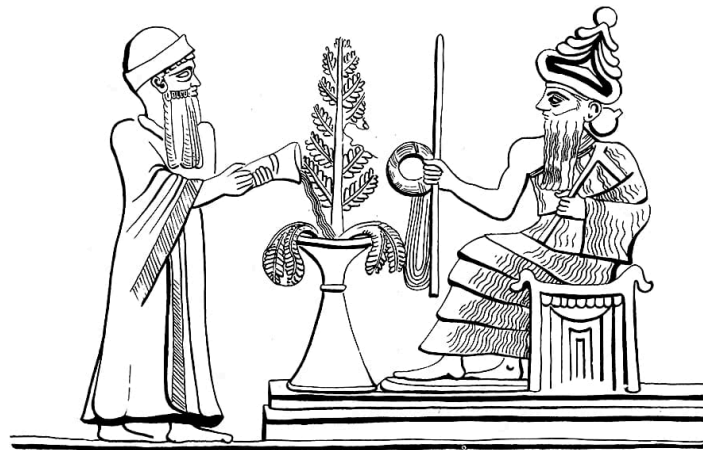


SPL. [National Geographic.](#)

Trees and the Gods

Ur-Nammu of Ur (2060-1955 B.C.) offering a libation to a tree, which apparently represents the moon god Nanna, who sits enthroned behind it (cf. 239). The beneficent power of the god is present in the tree (cf. 253-

55). The king, in strengthening the tree by a drink offering, enhances that power. In return, the tree dispenses life-giving water.



Keel, Othmar (2015), page 135. Creation: *Biblical Theologies in the Context of the Ancient Near East*. Eisenbrauns.

The Motif of a Divine Tree Protected by the Gods Comes from Mesopotamia

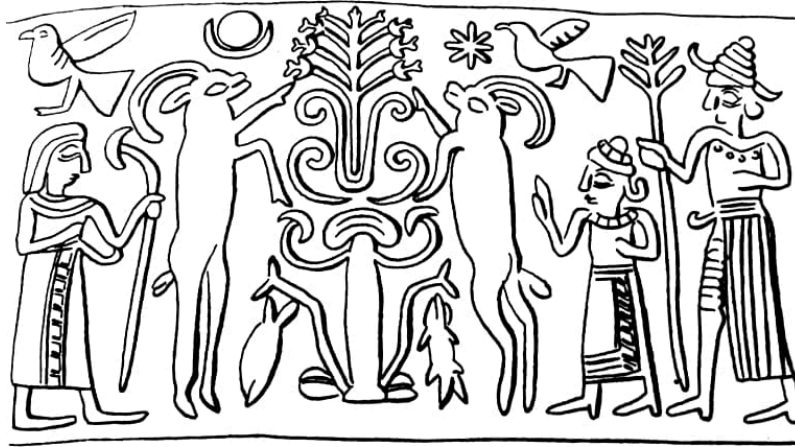
A carving from Nimrud shows goats around a tree of life, symbolizing its vitality, and then cherubim, showing that it's also the domain of the gods (also below, a plaque stitched to the chest of a deceased person in a tomb).



Keel, Othmar (2015), page 135. Creation: *Biblical Theologies in the Context of the Ancient Near East*. Eisenbrauns.

Trees of Life in Syria-Canaanite Tradition

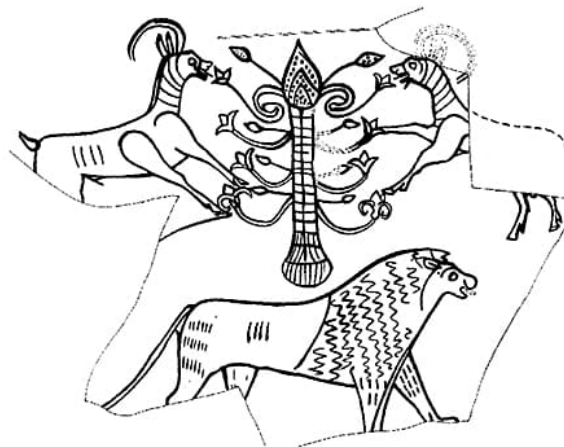
Syrian seal (1750-1550 B.C.): Two goats flank and eat from the cosmic world tree, symbolizing food given to all creatures of the land (birds, goats, fish) by the gods who stand nearby. To the right, the giant is the storm god with his plant-scepter.



Keel, Othmar (2015). "Image #21," *Creation: Biblical Theologies in the Context of the Ancient Near East*. Eisenbrauns.

Kuntillet 'Ajrud (Sinai Peninsula), 9th-8th Century B.C.

This image was found in a fortress in the Sinai peninsula, with an inscription that mentions Yahweh and Asherah. The image was certainly drawn by an Israelite, who here shows familiarity with the ancient Near Eastern motif of the tree of life.



[Wikipedia](#).

Summary of Ancient Tree Imagery

Osborne concludes that tree imagery in the ancient Near East is interwoven in three ways.

1. Abundance and prosperity from the gods are depicted as abundant gardens and tree-filled forests.
2. Deities and their powers to give fertility are regularly associated with tree symbols.
3. Kings who mediate the power of the gods are either the caretakers of trees or symbolized as trees themselves.

Comparisons and Contrasts with Genesis 1-2

The biblical images take on a life of their own and a unique meaning within the Bible. But they are also rooted in the ancient cultures of Israel's neighbors.

Seeing the garden/tree imagery as a design pattern of Heaven on Earth in its ancient context is helpful in understanding why garden imagery is so pervasive throughout the Bible. It was the language of Heaven and Earth in the time of the biblical authors.

In Genesis 1-2, all humanity is given the royal task of stewarding the garden and its trees. This fits with the pattern of the image of God, where all humanity assumes the role of the king.

The tree is not divine but a symbol of divine life and abundance that can be internalized (eaten). The tree is not magic; rather it is an image of proximity to the source of divine life.

Jesus and Garden Imagery

The New Testament authors build upon this imagery to communicate what was accomplished through the life and death of Jesus. Take for example the opening of John's Gospel.

John 1:14 NASB

And the Word became flesh, and **dwelt** among us, and we saw his **glory**, glory as of the only begotten from the Father, full of grace and truth.

When you look at Jesus, you are seeing the divine glory that used to only be accessible by one priest, one time a year in the temple. But now, what was contained "in the middle" is now unleashed in Jesus. Throughout the rest of the Gospel, John continues to use this Eden/temple imagery, like when Jesus is called the water of life, the vine of God's life, the new temple, and when he is crucified and lifted up on the high place.

Reflection Question

The garden of Eden is more than just a safe and fertile piece of land—it's a symbol of a bigger reality. What does the garden of Eden represent?